THE CLUB

by Molly Baz

Crispy-Crackly Minty-Pea Lasagna

SERVES: 8

You know how lasagna is, for the most part kinda all one textural experience unless you're the lucky one who gets a crispy crunchy corner piece? NO LONGER. This lasagna gets topped with an entire sheet of olive oil drizzled pasta, which bakes until it turns into a pasta cracker such that NO ONE needs to take a knee and eat a boring middle piece. Peas (frozen or fresh!), mint, spinach, ricotta, mozz, and parm make up the filling, and if you can get your hands on some Meyer lemons, they are an optional but highly recommended addition. Chopped up and scattered throughout the lasagna, they yield little bursts of floral lemony brightness as you eat. A total textural springtime delight.

ACTIVE TIME: 30 MINS
TOTAL TIME: 1 HR 30 MINS

PRODUCE

- 5 cloves garlic
- 2 cups (1 ½ ounces) packed mint leaves, from 1 large or 2 small bunches
- 1 Meyer lemon

PANTRY

- 1 pound dry lasagna noodles
- Kosher salt and freshly ground black pepper
- ⅓ cup olive oil, plus more for greasing noodles and the pan

DAIRY

- 3 ½ ounces Pecorino Romano
- 8 ounces (not fresh) whole milk mozzarella
- 1 pound fresh ricotta
- ⅔ cup heavy cream
- 1 large egg

FROZEN

- One (16-ounce) bag frozen peas
- One (10-ounce) bag frozen spinach

1. DO SOME PREP:

- Defrost one (16-ounce) bag frozen peas and one (12-ounce) bag frozen spinach, either overnight in the refrigerator, or by letting them sit out on your countertop for a bit. (You can also place the bags in a bowl of warm water, using another bowl to keep them submerged.) Squeeze as much water from the spinach using your hands or a kitchen towel.
- Finely grate 3 ½ ounces Pecorino Romano. You should have about 3 ½ cups if using a microplane. Grate 8 ounces mozzarella on the large holes of a box grater.
- Boil 1 pound lasagna noodles in a large pot of water seasoned generously with salt. Cook 2-3 minutes less than package instructions, until very al dente. Drain and

transfer to a small plate or sheet pan. Coat noodles lightly with olive oil. (Cover with plastic wrap if not constructing lasagna immediately.)

2. MAKE LASAGNA FILLING:

- Combine 1 pound fresh ricotta, 5 cloves garlic, the spinach, and 10 ounces (about 2 ½ cups) of the peas in a food processor, reserving the remaining peas for constructing the lasagna. Process until a homogenous green color forms, scraping down the sides of the bowl once or twice.
- Add ⅓ cup olive oil, ⅔ cup heavy cream, 1 egg, half of the grated pecorino romano, 1 tablespoon plus 1 teaspoon salt, and lots and lots of black pepper. Process until fully combined. Add 2 cups packed mint leaves and pulse just to combine. Season to taste with salt and pepper.

3. CONSTRUCT AND BAKE:

- Preheat oven to 400 degrees and line a baking sheet with parchment paper.
- Lightly grease a 2 ½- to 3-quart baking dish with olive oil.
- Roughly chop 1 Meyer lemon. Transfer to a bowl, discarding seeds.
- Spread 1 cup of the ricotta mixture on the bottom of the pan. Top with one layer of lasagna noodles. Now for the layers: Top with one-third of the remaining ricotta mixture, one-third of the mozzarella, one-third of the chopped lemons, and one-third of the remaining 6 ounces peas, and another layer of noodles. Construct 2 more layers like this, finishing with pasta noodles. (In total, you should have 4 layers of noodles and 3 layers of ricotta-pea-cheeses-lemon filling.) Don't worry if the lasagna noodles hang over the sides of the pan– this is actually good! The more surface area on the top, the more crackly, cheesy pasta noodles you'll have for serving. (You may have a noodle or two leftover, as well.)
- Cover with tin foil and place on the prepared baking sheet. Transfer to the oven and bake 30 minutes.
  Increase heat to 450 degrees. Remove pan from oven and uncover. Drizzle the noodles generously with olive oil and sprinkle with the remaining 1 ½ ounces pecorino. They should be well-showered with the cheese! Return to oven and bake 28-34 more minutes, until noodles are ridiculously crisp and burnished.
- Let rest 15 minutes before cutting and serving.

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